

PART I

On November 3, 2025, at the Abu Dhabi International Petroleum Exhibition and Conference (ADIPEC), two men signed a document that commits Malaysian petroleum revenues for the next five years. The event was photographed, published in press releases, and reported in the financial news. What the photographs did not show was the corporate structure behind the signature.

The entity that now holds the rights to a substantial portion of Malaysia's domestic gas supply is **SEARAH Limited** — a company registered in England and Wales (Company No. 17027115), incorporated at ENI House, 8th Floor, London. Its two shareholders are **PETRONAS Carigali International Ventures Ltd** and **Eni Lasingo Pte**, each holding 50 percent.

THE FIGURE

USD 15 BILLION — "in excess of USD 15 billion over five years" — Eni press release, November 2025.

~~The governing law is the Companies Act 2006, the jurisdiction is England, and the company secretary function runs through Eni's London office. If something goes wrong with this agreement — a dispute, a breach, a~~
The Deal That Could Reshape Malaysia's Petroleum Future
The deal is structured to ensure that Malaysia's petroleum future is under Eni's authority. The contract resolves in England.

How a RM70 Billion Gas Agreement Was Structured — and Who Was Left Out of the Room

— Arif Fazil

PART II

PETRONAS has operated in Malaysia for 50 years. It has always been the national vehicle — the entity through which Malaysia's petroleum wealth is managed on behalf of Malaysians. The Companies Act 2016 governs PETRONAS. Malaysian courts have jurisdiction. Malaysian regulators have authority.

The SEARAH structure places Malaysian gas receipts into a UK vehicle. The structure matters for three specific reasons:

- **English law governs.** Any dispute between PETRONAS and Eni is heard in England, not Malaysia.
- **No BIT protects Malaysia.** Malaysia has no BIT with Italy, and the previous UK-Malaysia BIT has lapsed. Eni can pursue remedies under English law. Malaysia has no equivalent international instrument.
- **The company secretary is Eni's function.** The operational administration of SEARAH Limited is managed from Eni's London office.

Eni has disclosed that it uses the "satellite model" in multiple jurisdictions — Norway, Angola, the United Kingdom. It is their standard approach. The question is not whether this structure is unusual. The question is whether it serves Malaysia's interests.

PART III

July 2017	PETROS incorporated — 100%-owned by Sarawak government
Aug 2024	Kasawari gas field, Block SK316 offshore Sarawak, begins production
Jun 2025	Framework Agreement signed in Kuala Lumpur — both CEOs attend

Aug 2025	PETROS sues PETRONAS in Kuching High Court — unlicensed gas supply in Sarawak
Oct 2025	Anwar speaks with Meloni — both agree to expedite the deal
Nov 3, 2025	Investment Agreement signed at ADIPEC Abu Dhabi — both CEOs sign
Feb 11, 2026	SEARAH Limited incorporated at UK Companies House (Company No. 17027115)
Feb 25, 2026	Kuching High Court rules on bank guarantee — jurisdiction sent to Federal Court
Mar 16, 2026	Federal Court allows PETRONAS constitutional challenge on Sarawak petroleum laws
Mar 30, 2026	Company changes name from SEARA ENERGY LIMITED to SEARAH LIMITED — 14 days after ruling
Mid-2026	SEARAH expected to begin operations — closing conditions still being satisfied

SEARAH

The March 30 name change is the most documented fact in this investigation. UK Companies House filing dated March 30, 2026 — exactly 14 days after the Federal Court decision. The change from SEARA ENERGY LIMITED to SEARAH LIMITED was filed and processed in London. No explanation has been offered for why this happened in the 14 days following a widely reported court ruling.

PART IV

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What are the specific terms of the joint venture? Revenue share? Cost-recovery mechanism? What happens if gas production falls below forecast?

Kasawari (Block SK316) is listed in PETRONAS's published asset portfolio. Is it held within SEARAH Limited? What mechanism placed a Malaysian upstream asset inside a UK-registered company?

On October 21, 2025, Anwar met Meloni in Kuala Lumpur. Was the SEARAH structure disclosed to Cabinet before the November 3 signing?

SEARAH's registered address is BINTULU, SARAWAK. Was PETROS consulted before the UK incorporation was adopted?

There is no record of a parliamentary briefing on SEARAH in the Hansard database as of May 2026. Has Parliament been asked to approve this structure?

Eni's satellite model is used in Norway, Angola, and the UK. Did PETRONAS propose this structure, or Eni? If Eni proposed it, what consideration did PETRONAS give to the jurisdictional implications?

What are the conditions precedent to closing? Has the Malaysian government insisted on structural modifications as a condition of approval?

PART V

The Federal Court's decision to allow the PETRONAS constitutional challenge on March 16, 2026 is significant not because it resolves the dispute — it does not — but because the court has agreed the question is serious enough to hear.

The core issue: whether the Petroleum Development Act 1974 validly applies in Sarawak, or whether Sarawak's own petroleum laws take precedence. If PETROS prevails, PETRONAS's operating authority in Sarawak is weakened. If PETRONAS prevails, the PETROS framework is weakened.

Neither outcome changes the fields themselves. But those assets are now, in their corporate holding structure, partly inside SEARAH Limited — a UK company governed by English law. The RM70 billion question is not academic.

SEARAH

- Companies House UK, Company No. 17027115 (SEARAH Limited) — Incorporation, PSC register, officer list, filing history
- Eni media releases, November 2025 and March 2026 — Investment Agreement, SEARAH structure
- PETRONAS media releases, November 2025 — JV partnership confirmation

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- NO active UK-Malaysia BIT
- Malaysian Parliament Hansard — no record of parliamentary briefing on SEARAH structure found
- Malaysian Federal Court record, March 16, 2026 — PETRONAS constitutional challenge admitted
- Reuters, October 2025 and March 2026

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- Wood Mackenzie press release, February 28, 2025 — PETRONAS-Eni combination analysis
- Global Arbitration Review — ICSID Case No. ARB/20/48 (Eni vs Nigeria)
- Fulcrum Singapore (ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute), April 2026
- Milan Court records, March 2021 — Descalzi/Eni OPL 245 acquittal

- ✓ SEARAH Limited (Company No. 17027115) — UK-registered, incorporated February 11, 2026 at ENI House, London.
- ✓ 50% owned by PETRONAS Carigali International Ventures, 50% by Eni Lasmo Plc.
- ✓ Deal valued at "in excess of USD 15 billion over five years" — Eni press release, November 2025.
- ✓ Company governed by Companies Act 2006 (English law).
- ✓ NO active BIT between Malaysia and Italy or the United Kingdom — confirmed by UNCTAD, April 2026.
- ✓ MLNG Bintulu — one of world's largest LNG export facilities; supplies Japan, Korea, Taiwan, China.

WHAT REQUIRES FURTHER INVESTIGATION

- The specific terms of the JV agreement between PETRONAS and Eni are not public.
- Whether Malaysian Parliament was formally notified has not been confirmed.
- Whether PETROS was consulted before the SEARAH structure was finalised has not been confirmed.
- Whether Malaysian legal counsel reviewed the UK incorporation has not been confirmed.
- Whether Block SK316 or other producing fields are held within SEARAH Limited has not been confirmed.

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CORRECTION NOTICE: Previous editions incorrectly stated that an Italy-Malaysia BIT (1988) was in force. UNCTAD confirmed (April 2026): NO such treaty exists. BIT claim rejected. The correct statement: NO BIT protects this arrangement. English law governs. No ICSID route exists for Malaysia.

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All claims cross-checked against primary sources: Companies House UK, Eni press releases, UNCTAD Investment Policy Hub, Malaysian Parliament Hansard, Federal Court records. F2 WITNESS standard: evidence must be verifiable, not merely credible.

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